

FIRST CUSTOMER

First Customer — 10 Days to Your First Paying Customers — Day 3: The Opener That Earns Attention

Study guide · Self-study

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How to Use This Guide

This is your guide for Day 3 of 10 Days to Your First Paying Customers. You work alone, at your own pace, inside your own business. Read a section, then stop and do the small task in it before you move on. Write your answers down. Say your opener out loud until it sounds like you, not like a script you memorized.

Day 1 gave you your target customer and the buying trigger that makes them start looking. Day 2 gave you places to find them and signals that tell you they are ready. Today you learn what to say in the first seconds, when you finally have their attention. Everything here applies to calls, texts, emails, messages in a community, and the first minute of a meeting.

The guide is short on theory and long on practice. The practice is the point. A founder who can hold attention for one extra minute gets a conversation. A founder who cannot never finds out whether the offer was good.

☐ Keep a pen and paper next to you for your written answers.

☐ Say each script out loud at least three times, in your own words.

☐ Do the Upskill Challenge before you start Day 4.

> **NOTES**
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> Do not read the Model Answers section until you have written your own answers to What Would You Say? Your words first, models second.

Today's Objectives (KASU)

By the end of this unit you will have one opener you can use today, on a real person, without feeling pushy.

Knowledge: You will know the First-Contact Standard (MEDJAY adaptation, based on Kahneman, Brehm and Guyer et al.): a four-behavior structure for every first contact, used in this order: Low Threat, Autonomy, Relevance, Curiosity. You will know why the order matches the silent questions in a buyer's head.

Attitude: You will stop treating the first seconds as a pitch you have to deliver and start treating them as a decision the other person makes about you. Your job is to earn their voluntary next minute, not to extract it.

Skill: You will be able to open a call, text, email or meeting with a calm introduction, an easy exit, one true reason this is about them, and one easy open question.

Upskill: You will be able to adapt the same four behaviors to a channel where you get no reply at all, such as a text or an email subject line, and to a shift in tone when the person answers coldly.

> **NOTES**
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> Write the four behaviors on a note you can see while you work: Low Threat, Autonomy, Relevance, Curiosity. Order matters.

Why the First Seconds Decide Everything

When your call or message arrives, the person on the other end is not evaluating your product yet. They are answering one question: is this safe, and is this relevant to me? Until those two answers are yes, nothing you say about features, price or value gets processed properly.

Kahneman's two modes of thinking explain why. Busy people run on fast, automatic System 1 thinking for almost everything. System 1 does not analyze; it sorts. Unknown caller, possible sales pitch, unknown sender, possible waste of time. The sort happens before you finish your first sentence. If the sort says threat or irrelevant, the person's attention leaves, and you get a brush-off that has nothing to do with your offer.

There is a second force at work: reactance, described by Brehm in 1966. People push back when they feel their freedom being taken away. A pushy opener, a fake urgency line, or a demand for two minutes feels like pressure on their choices. The reflex is to resist, even if they might have been interested. An opener that gives them a clear way to say no removes that pressure. Feeling free to leave is what makes it safe to stay.

The First-Contact Standard works because it answers the person's silent questions in the order they arise. Is this safe? Who are you, said calmly. Can I get out of this? Yes, here is how. Is this about me? Here is one true reason. Do I want to continue? Here is one easy question you can answer in a sentence. The order follows the person's silent questions in the first seconds, which is why it works as a structure rather than a script.

> **NOTES**
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> If a call goes badly in the first ten seconds, the cause is almost always a skipped step, not a bad product.

The Four Behaviors, One at a Time

Low Threat. Open calmly and unhurried. Say who you are and who you represent, at a natural pace. This answers the person's first silent question: is this safe? Pace does more work than words here. Fast speech signals nervousness or a rehearsed pitch, and both raise the guard. One clear sentence with your name and your business is enough.

Autonomy. Give the person a clear, easy way to decline or say not now. This is not a trick and it is not weakness. It is what makes it safe to stay. When people know they can end the conversation at any moment, they stop spending energy defending against you and start listening.

Relevance. Give one true, credible reason this contact is about them, not you. One reason. The reason has to be real: they asked about something, they posted something, they are hiring, they run a shop near yours. This answers: is this relevant? If you cannot name a true reason, you are not ready to make contact. Go back to Day 2 and find a signal.

Curiosity. Ask one easy, open question that invites them to talk. This answers: do I want to continue? by giving them something easy to say. Easy means short and answerable without preparation. Open

means it cannot be answered yes or no. What caught your eye? What are you working on this month? What made you start looking now?

> **NOTES**
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> A common mistake is replacing the whole structure with 'How are you today?' and 'I just need two minutes.' Neither says who you are, neither gives an exit, neither is about the customer.

One Structure, Every Channel

The same four behaviors apply to every moment where a customer decides whether to keep engaging, in any channel: phone, text, email, meetings.

On a call, Low Threat is your calm name and business. In a text, it is a first line that makes clear who you are and why you are writing. Keep texts short, well under a paragraph, with an easy no built in. In an email, the subject line is your opener. A subject that names the person's own situation is doing the work of Low Threat and Relevance at once. A vague subject gets sorted away with the rest.

In a meeting or a visit, every new room or new person is a new first contact. A founder walking into a shop to meet the owner starts the structure again: who you are, an easy exit, one true reason, one open question.

There is a useful test for any first contact. Read your first two lines and ask: could this have been sent to anyone? If yes, it is not ready. Relevance is the step founders skip most often, because they are excited about their offer. The customer is not excited about your offer yet. They are wondering why you are in their day.

> **NOTES**
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> When you write a text or email, count the words before you send. If the message takes more than a few seconds to read, cut it.

Worked Example: One Call, Four Behaviors

Practice example: a founder runs a small software business that helps independent gyms manage class bookings. The founder calls the owner of a neighborhood gym, Nadia, who recently posted that she was turning people away from a full class.

Low Threat: 'Hi Nadia, this is Sam Rivera from Bookline. I help small gyms fill their classes without double-booking.' Calm, one sentence, who and what.

Autonomy: 'If this is a bad moment, just tell me and I will follow up another time.' A real exit, said without apology.

Relevance: 'I saw your post about turning people away from Thursday classes, so I thought it was worth one call.' One true, checkable reason.

Curiosity: 'What is happening on Thursdays right now?' Open, easy, about her.

Notice what the founder did not do: no feature list, no price, no 'two minutes of your time.' The call asks for a minute by earning it. If Nadia says 'busy right now,' the founder has a clean exit and a reason to be welcomed back: 'Understood. I will send one short message so you have my name.'

A second setting:

Practice example: a consultant who helps cafes open second locations texts a cafe owner who just announced a new site. The text: 'Hi Ana, it is Tom from Northline. I help cafe owners plan a second site without overcommitting on rent. If this is not useful, ignore this message. What is the biggest unknown about the second location right now?' It names him, offers an exit, gives one true reason, and ends with one easy question.

> **NOTES**
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> The question at the end is the smallest part and the most important. If the customer answers it, you have a conversation. You do not need to be interesting; you need to be easy to talk to.

Reflection

Before you move on, answer these in writing, in your own words. Two or three sentences each is enough.

Think of the last time a stranger called or messaged you trying to sell something. What did you feel in the first five seconds? What did you do? Now compare that with what you have been sending to prospects this week. What would that person have felt in their first five seconds with you?

Then think about the last time a cold approach worked on you, and you actually stayed on the call or replied to the message. What did the other person do that made you stay? Most people name one thing: the person made it easy to say no, or the person clearly knew something about their situation. That is the structure at work, even when the person using it never heard the name.

> **NOTES**
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> If you cannot remember a cold approach that worked on you, ask whether any of your own contacts were ever won that way. The pattern will be the same.

What Would You Say?

Write your own answer to each situation before you look at the Model Answers. Write in the words you would actually use out loud. Keep your response brief; the principle behind it matters more than the exact wording.

The situations:

1. A B2B call to a business owner you have never met, whose business recently started hiring.

2. A message in an online community where you are a member, to someone who asked for a recommendation for a service like yours.

3. A B2C text to a person who filled in a form on your website last week.

4. Someone answers your call with a flat 'I am not interested' before you have said anything.

5. An email where the open rate is fine but nobody ever replies.

For each one, name which of the four behaviors you were most likely to skip before this unit, and what you will do instead.

> **NOTES**
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> Write first, then compare. If your answer sounds like a script written by someone else, rewrite it until it sounds like you.

Key Takeaways

Summarize the day in your own words underneath each line.

1. The first contact is not a pitch. It is a decision the customer makes about whether to give you one more minute.

2. The First-Contact Standard (MEDJAY adaptation, based on Kahneman, Brehm and Guyer et al.) is a structure, not a script: Low Threat, Autonomy, Relevance, Curiosity, in that order. Its goal is an opening the other person chooses to continue: one that earns attention instead of demanding it.

3. The order matters because it follows the person's silent questions: is this safe, can I leave, is this about me, do I want to continue.

4. Autonomy is the step founders skip most after relevance. An easy no is what makes a yes feel safe.

5. Relevance must be true. If you cannot name one real reason this contact is about them, you are not ready to send it.

6. The same four behaviors apply in every channel. In email, the subject line is your opener.

7. Your final question should be easy and open. Short answers lower the cost of replying, and a reply is all you are asking for today.

Quiz

Answer each question, then check the answer key below. Aim for 4 out of 5 before you start Day 4.

1. What is the main goal of a first contact?

- **A.** To deliver your full pitch before the person loses interest
- **B.** To earn a voluntary next minute of the person's attention
- **C.** To ask for a purchase decision as early as possible
- **D.** To establish your expertise with a detailed explanation of your service

2. Which order matches the First-Contact Standard (MEDJAY adaptation, based on Kahneman, Brehm and Guyer et al.)?

   A. Relevance, Curiosity, Low Threat, Autonomy

   B. Low Threat, Autonomy, Relevance, Curiosity

   C. Curiosity, Relevance, Autonomy, Low Threat

   D. Autonomy, Low Threat, Curiosity, Relevance

3. Why does giving the customer an easy way to say 'not now' make them more likely to keep talking?

   A. It proves you do not need the sale, which raises your status

   B. It shortens the call so you can reach more people

   C. Feeling free to leave removes the pressure on their choices, which makes it safe to stay

   D. It tricks the customer into feeling obligated to stay

4. A founder opens with: 'Hi, this is Alex from Brightside. How are you today? I just need two minutes of your time.' What is the main problem?

   A. It is too long and should be cut in half

   B. It gives no true reason this is about the customer and no easy exit, and demands time

   C. It names the founder and the business, which raises suspicion

   D. It asks a question too early in the call

5. You send an email to a prospect and nobody replies. Which change best follows the First-Contact Standard?

   A. Rewrite the subject line to name the person's own situation, add an easy exit and end with one easy question

   B. Send the same email three more times so it gets noticed

   C. Add more detail about your background and qualifications

   D. Add a deadline to create urgency

Upskill Challenge

Your challenge before Day 4: make five real first contacts using the four behaviors, in at least two channels, and log what happened.

Use prospects from your Day 1 target customer and Day 2 list. You do not need permission from anyone. These are your own prospects, in your own business.

For each contact, write down: the channel, your Low Threat line, your Autonomy line, your Relevance reason, your Curiosity question, and the customer's exact reply or non-reply. Then mark which of the four behaviors was hardest for you to say without feeling awkward.

At least one of the five should be a call, because a voice makes pace and tone visible. At least one should be a text or email with no reply, so you practice the version where you get nothing back.

Then pick your single best opener and write it on a card. Keep the card where you work. You will use it again tomorrow, when Day 4 teaches you what to ask once the person starts talking.

☐ Five first contacts made, in at least two channels

☐ Each one logged with the four lines and the customer's reply

☐ Written one-sentence conclusion: which behavior you skipped and why

☐ Best opener written on a card and kept in view

> **NOTES**
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> A brush-off is information, not failure. A calm second attempt that adds a true reason is reasonable; a repeated or clear no is a real no, so log it and move on.

Model Answers

These are examples, not scripts. Use them to check your thinking, then write your own again in your own words.

1. B2B call, business recently hiring. 'Hi Priya, this is Marco from Fieldline. I help operations teams keep new hires productive in their first month. If now is a bad time, just say so. I noticed you have three open roles in operations. What is slowing down onboarding right now?' Why it works: calm name and business, real exit, one true reason drawn from the hiring signal, one open question.

2. Community message, person asked for a recommendation. 'Hi Dan, I am Lena from Greenline. You asked for a service like this in the group yesterday. If it is not useful, no problem at all. We do the same work for shops your size. What is the part you are unsure about?' Why it works: answers their stated need instead of pitching, keeps the exit real, asks about their uncertainty rather than your credentials.

3. B2C text, form filled in last week. 'Hi Jo, it is Sam from Harbor Clean. You asked about a deep clean last week. If this is not a good time, just tell me. What matters most, timing or price?' Why it works: short, names the person, references their own action, offers an easy exit, and ends with one easy choice.

4. Flat 'not interested' before you speak. 'Fair enough, I will not take your time. I was calling because of the ad you placed about weekend hours. If that is not a priority, that is fine. Would another month be a better time to check in?' Why it works: accepts the no without arguing, keeps the exit genuine, restates one true reason, and offers a real, low-pressure choice. A repeated or clear no is a genuine decline, so respect it and end.

5. Email nobody replies to. Keep it very short. Subject: the person's own situation, such as 'Weekend hours at your shop.' Body: who you are, one true reason, an easy exit, one easy question. Why it works: the subject line carries Low Threat and Relevance, the body asks for a reply rather than a purchase, and there is nothing to read through before answering.

- Quiz answers:
- 1. B. The first contact earns the next minute; selling comes after attention is given freely.
- 2. B. Low Threat, Autonomy, Relevance, Curiosity, because the order follows the person's silent questions.

- 3. C. Reactance research shows people resist when their freedom feels threatened; a real exit lowers the threat.
- 4. B. 'How are you today' and 'I just need two minutes' fail Low Threat, Autonomy and Relevance at once.
- 5. A. In email the subject line is your opener; relevance plus an easy exit plus one easy question is the structure.

> **NOTES**
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> Your wording should sound like you. If any model line feels unnatural in your mouth, replace it with a plain sentence that carries the same behavior.

References

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